though. I know I had a bit of a dip in form in the latter half of the 2010 IPL, and none of us scored any meaningful runs at the T20 World Cup in the West Indies, but overall I think my new maturity should still see me play plenty of big innings.

My form in the recent Friends Provident T20 competition – county cricket's 20/20 tournament – was, for example, very promising. For Yorkshire, I averaged 36.91 and scored my first 20/20 100 as well.

I got a 90 not out against the West Indies at the Wanderers in 2007, a 98 against Northants for Glamorgan in 2008, and 92 for the Cape Cobras against the Dolphins in 2009, but that's the closest I had got.

My new sense of responsibility has also contributed to my willingness to be more outspoken at team meetings. Not when I'm playing for the Proteas, obviously, for reasons I have already outlined, but certainly with the Cape Cobras and the Deccan Chargers. Provided the team is unified, then I have the confidence to say my piece at meetings.

At the Cobras, for example, I've been helping out the younger guys with technical aspects of their game, and I've also given them advice on what to do in certain situations in a match. Senior players gave me some crucial advice when I first started out – I mentioned Brian McMillan telling me to line up my head with off-stump in Chapter 2 – and I've been passing some of that information on. I don't try to be too prescriptive. I just give the guys food for thought, really.

I think I can play a role in helping some of the youngsters raise their goals so that they can realise their true potential. I had a long chat with a few of my younger Cobras teammates in 2009. I told them that they were in a comfort zone and were not working hard enough to improve their game beyond being domestic stars. I think I have a lot to offer these youngsters, as many of them coming through now probably have a similar mindset to the one I had back then, both regarding their cricket and how they live their lives. Especially in the new world of 20-over cricket, these guys are earning money, playing aggressive cricket and leading quite fast lifestyles. I have been through it all, and I've come out the other end.

I look at these okes and see how, season after season, they're just not improving to higher levels, as they should be. There might be a slight improvement from one year to the next, but it's not enough. In your early twenties, you've got, like, five or six years to use domestic cricket as a platform to gain experience – to help improve your physical and mental